

Ureteral Stent (Kidney Drainage Tube)

Patient Information · Living with a stent, and why it must come out on time

WARWIKI

A ureteral stent is a thin, soft tube inside your body. It runs from your kidney down to your bladder and keeps urine draining. Nothing shows on the outside unless your stent has a string. Most stents are temporary, and **every stent must be removed or changed on time.**

Why You Have a Stent

The **ureter** is the tube that carries urine from the kidney to the bladder. A stent keeps it open when:

- A **stone**, swelling or scar blocks the ureter, or something presses on it from outside
- The ureter or kidney has had **surgery** or an injury and needs time to heal
- A new kidney has been joined to the bladder (kidney transplant)

Each end of the stent is curled to hold it in place: one in the kidney and one in the bladder. It is usually placed through the urethra with a thin scope and X-ray, while you are asleep or numb.

Benefits and Risks in Numbers

about
8 in 10

had urgency or some pain while a stent was in after stone surgery

45 in 100

had painful spells while taking an alpha-blocker medicine, vs 76 in 100 without it

nearly
17 in 100

stents in people with stones were crusted when left in longer than 4 months

Numbers are averages from published studies. Your own risk may differ; ask your team.

Living With a Stent

- **Common and expected:** going often, sudden urges, burning, and pink or blood-tinged urine that comes and goes.
- **Side or kidney ache**, often when you pass urine or are active. Urine can flow back up the stent when you void.
- These symptoms usually **stop once the stent is out.**
- **What helps:** drink extra fluids for the first day or two. Your team may prescribe a medicine that relaxes the ureter (an alpha-blocker) or the bladder.

Learn the Terms

Ureter

The tube that carries urine from each kidney to the bladder.

Stent (double-J stent)

A soft hollow tube with a curl at each end. It keeps the ureter open from the inside.

Stent on a string

A stent with a thread that comes out of the urethra. Pulling the thread removes the stent.

Cystoscopy

A look into the bladder with a thin camera. Used to place and remove most stents.

Crusting (encrustation)

Minerals from urine that build up on a stent left in too long. A crusted stent can block and be hard to remove.

Nephrostomy

A different drain: a tube placed through the back straight into the kidney.

A stent must never be forgotten. A stent left in too long can crust over, block the kidney, cause infection or stones, and may need a bigger operation to remove. Short-term stents usually come out within about 6 weeks. Long-term stents are changed on a schedule. If you have not heard about removal within 4–6 weeks, call the team that placed it.

Before You Leave, Ask

- Which side is my stent on, and does it have a string?
- When should it come out or be changed, and who will do it?
- Whom do I call if I have not heard about removal?

How a Stent Comes Out

- **Without a string:** a short office visit. Numbing gel goes into the urethra, a thin flexible scope is passed into the bladder, and the stent is gently pulled out. It takes a few minutes, and you go home right after.
- **With a string:** pulling the string brings the whole stent out. Your team will tell you the day and whether you or they remove it. In one study, about 8 in 10 people removed their own stent at home without trouble.
- If a string stent **falls out early**, or the **string breaks off**, call your team. A stent left behind still needs to be removed.

Tell Your Team

- Before any other surgery or scan, that you have a stent and when it is due out
- If you take **blood thinners**, and before any removal visit
- If you move, change doctors, or miss a removal visit

Long-Term Stents

Some people need a stent for months or years, for example when something presses on the ureter from outside. These stents are **changed on a schedule**, and the time limit depends on the type of stent. Keep every change visit, even when you feel well. Rarely, a long-term stent wears into a nearby artery, mostly after pelvic cancer surgery or radiation. With a long-term stent, call the same day about any blood in the urine, even if it stops.

Call the office that placed your stent if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Side pain or burning that your medicines do not control
- Blood in the urine that is getting heavier
- A string stent that came out early, or no removal date

Go to an emergency department if:

- Fever with shaking chills, or you feel very unwell
- You pass very little or no urine
- Urine like red wine or with clots, or severe pain
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. The stent keeps urine draining from your kidney while it heals or a blockage is treated.
2. Urges, burning, blood in the urine and side pain are common and stop once it is out.
3. Know your removal date. A stent must never be forgotten.